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To cite this article: Antero Garcia (2017) Privilege, Power, and Dungeons & Dragons: How Systems Shape Racial and Gender Identities in Tabletop Role-Playing Games, *Mind, Culture, and Activity*, 24:3, 232-246, DOI: [10.1080/10749039.2017.1293691](https://doi.org/10.1080/10749039.2017.1293691)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/10749039.2017.1293691>



Published online: 07 Apr 2017.



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Privilege, Power, and Dungeons & Dragons: How Systems Shape Racial and Gender Identities in Tabletop Role-Playing Games

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ABSTRACT

This article takes a cultural-historical approach to analyzing how systems shape the assumptions, identities, and experiences of their users. Focusing on how the tabletop role-playing game Dungeons & Dragons is built on a system of play that has grown and shifted over the course of 40 years, this study emphasizes the central role that systems play in mediating the experiences of participants. By focusing on depictions of gender, race, and power in Dungeons & Dragons—as a singular cultural practice—this study highlights how researchers must attend to cultural production both *around* and *within* systems.

Once upon a time, long, long ago, in a realm called the midwestern United States—specifically the states of Minnesota and Wisconsin—a group of friends gathered together to forever alter the history of gaming.
— Preface, *Dungeons & Dragons Player's Handbook Fifth Edition* (Wizards of the Coast, 2014a, p. 4)

Forty years since the official release of the world's first role-playing game (RPG), Dungeons & Dragons (D&D; Arneson & Gygax, 1974), the preface to the fifth edition of the game invokes a self-created mythology of how the system's midwestern creators defined a genre of play. Since its creation by gamers Gary Gygax and Dave Arneson, D&D has spawned numerous editions, playing variants, and other gaming systems. In addition, as the harbinger of an entire genre of codified tabletop play and video game tropes, D&D has significantly shaped the landscape of pop culture as portrayed in books, on screens (big and small), and via gaming consoles. The group of friends that “forever alter[ed]” the landscape of gaming and pop culture did so through the authorship of a rules system that dictated the constraints and ideologies for meaning making within RPGs.

As a system for “collaborative creation” within a fantasy-focused virtual world, D&D is an analog toolset for group production of cultural artifacts, narratives, and expressions of agency. The rules of D&D function as “constituents of culture” (Cole, 1998, p. 292), as they are artifacts that mediate group understanding and individual learning. In D&D, a group of players mutually construct and enact stories within a shared and pervasive “virtual world” (Boellstorff, Nardi, Pearce, & Taylor, 2012; Hine, 2011). With emphasis on tactical combat, narrative development, and spatial exploration, D&D illustrates powerful possibilities for socialization and learning. It also highlights key tropes in games—both digital and nondigital—that followed in its footsteps. From concepts of “leveling up” to “hit points” to classes of characters frequently chosen in online RPGs, D&D has shaped the landscape of games, learning, and virtual world exploration. It is also largely influenced by the designers' mutual passion for wargaming and for fantasy and science fiction pulp stories. These influences were embedded into the assumptions of D&D's system mechanics (Peterson, 2012). Particularly considering that D&D has shaped formative learning experiences of myriad gaming enthusiasts over the past 40 years of its existence, as well as its osmotic reflection in popular media

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today from *World of Warcraft* to *Game of Thrones* to its formative influence on acclaimed novelists like Junot Diaz (Schnelbach, 2016) and Ta-Nehisi Coates (2011), this article takes a cultural-historical perspective at how the systems that drive D&D's rules have shaped cultural understanding and learning within the game.

With collaborative creation at the origin of D&D, as well as key to how players explore and construct meaning within the D&D system, the values and influences that are embedded within the game must be excavated. In particular, D&D's role in shaping a history of symbolic violence in gaming culture is a legacy that is acknowledged but not empirically interrogated. In the context that this study was enmeshed, the systems of play were embroiled in "gamergate": "an online mob ostensibly about 'ethics in gaming journalism' that primarily targeted women for harassment" (Hurley, 2016, p. 15). By unpacking the embedded nature of inequality as related to games, gender, and race, this study helps explore conceptions and enactment of power in games and in broader gaming culture (Anthropy, 2012; Shaw, 2014). Ultimately, this study's emphasis on understanding the foundational depictions of race, gender, and power in a nondigital gaming system highlights how cultural-historical approaches to understanding learning within systems must begin with an understanding of the implicit biases of these systems. Further, this article's emphasis on how culturally constructed gaming systems shape the meaning making and experiences of their gaming communities speaks more broadly to the methodological challenges of studying systems and how they shape the communities around them.

Gutiérrez and Rogoff (2003) reminded us that "people *live* culture in a mutually constitutive manner in which it is not fruitful to tote up their characteristics as if they occur independently of culture, and of culture as if it occurs independently of people" (p. 21). If people, as participants in D&D, mediate lives and experiences within the virtual world of the game, the ways this world is bound by culturally informed rules systems play a significant role in shaping the experience and limitations on players' experiences. With this in mind, this study seeks to unpack the following questions:

- How are gender, race, and power defined explicitly and implicitly within the rules system of D&D?
- How do these constructions of gender, race, and power reflect the influences on the gaming system?
- How do these constructions shape player experiences within D&D virtual worlds in both the past and present?

By understanding the embedded values of virtual worlds, this study explores how systems shape specific forms of play. In doing so, this study illustrates Cole, Goncu, and Vadeboncoeur's (2015) claim that "cultural-historical and activity theory are approaches that investigate the past, as well as the present" (p. 1). Specifically, in looking at how a group of gaming creators 40 years ago continue to shape cultural meaning making in the present, I link systems of the past with their human authors and the biases they implicitly carry into their work. As Gall (1977) explained, systems are made by people and attract "systems-people" (p. 47).

Although this study confines its research to a singular (though changing over time) system of nondigital play, I enter this work to highlight how a cultural-historical approach can reveal problematic biases and assumptions within systems at large. How social constructions of schooling, informal learning environments, and exploration in gaming communities are mediated by systems of the past reveals potentially problematic blind spots for researchers in these spaces.

Reading historically across all of the editions of D&D published over the past 40 years—11 official D&D editions, as well as an additional "nonofficial" version—this article tracks how the rules that guide "the world's most popular roleplaying game" (Paizo Publishing, 2009, p. 4) reinforce assumptions of race and gender within tabletop gaming communities. To be clear, although I cast a critical eye at constructions of masculinity and femininity as depicted within the game, I do so recognizing that these constructions moved alongside, as well as reinforced, the temporal depictions of men and women in popular culture from the 1970s to the present. Clearly, particularly within a gaming

system that rewards players' imaginations, there are exceptions and shifts toward equity and inclusivity within gaming communities. However, the base ideological assumptions of D&D highlight how gaming culture alone is not the sole influence on the experiences of women within gaming communities; these experiences have been cultivated from embedded assumptions within the rules of D&D. To illustrate this point, I specifically look at conceptions of race and gender within D&D based on the text written, images displayed, and the noted influences across the editions. Ultimately, I enter this work seeking to understand the assumptions of these gaming systems *and* the methodological implications such systems have on the study of virtual worlds, their cultures, and their "communities of play" (Pearce & Artemesia, 2009).

Systems at work

D&D like other games, both digital and nondigital, is governed by a system of mechanics. The system of rules and constraints dictates what play means and how it is conducted. These complex "systems at work" (Bar-Yam, 2005) both replicate and model lived experiences while separating play from *normal*, nongaming activity. Arguably, whereas digital games adjudicate rules within the black box of computer code, human intuition, thinking, and interpretation supervise play in nondigital contexts such as playing D&D around a table. In considering how systems are overseen by individuals, particularly in the context of nondigital gameplay, O'Connor, Peck, and Cafarella's (2015) examination of how students navigate institutions of higher education reminds us that systems are layered with computational rules, guidelines, and instructions—"and yet humanity and subjectivity are always present" (p. 178). In particular, O'Connor et al.'s comment—originally within the context of exploring engineering students' course pathways—reminds researchers that culturally mediated spaces are constructed from the primordial soup of human knowledge and social biases. Despite the thousands of pages of rules (or millions of lines of code in digital contexts), these are systems made *by* individuals and *for* individuals.

Considering their creation by individuals, biases and inherent inequalities are both consciously and unconsciously embedded within systems. As argued in ongoing scholarship related to critical cyberculture (Silver & Massanari, 2006), foundational questions of oppression and exclusion in online contexts must foreground how scholars explore and unpack meaning in online and virtual environments. For example, Daniels (2013) contends that Internet-related research must acknowledge "the persistence of racism online while simultaneously recognizing the deep roots of racial inequality in existing social structures that shape technoculture" (p. 711). Likewise, De La Peña (2010) traced a lineage of scholarship detailing how "racial difference and whiteness are constructed through technology" (p. 924). Although the research in this article focuses on systems designed in the 1970s not intended to connect to online networks, the critical emphasis on how inequalities—particularly around race and gender—are embedded in cultural systems remains vital. Contexts of gaming are—like the Internet—"embedded in material, corporeal lives in complex ways" (Daniels, 2009, p. 117). This critical cyberculture research points to a further need for understanding the cultural and historical approaches to understanding nondigital gaming. The learning, meaning-making, and cultural mediation that happens within contexts governed by systems of rules—gaming, schooling, and broader communities of practice, for example—require researchers to consider how the cultural-historical repertoires (Gutiérrez & Rogoff, 2003) embedded within these systems affect what is produced and understood in these spaces. Rather than simply looking at how sexist practices or racial discrimination happen within and around online video game communities, this study suggests that these practices could be embedded *within* systems of play.

Further, as previously noted, gaming systems create spaces for cultural production that are safely ensconced from the rest of the world; Huizinga (1955) described this space as the "magic circle," noting that play stands "consciously outside 'ordinary' life as being 'not serious,' but at the same time absorbing the player utensil and utterly" (p. 13). Salen and Zimmerman (2004) elaborated on this concept, noting that this magic circle is "a special place in time and space created by a game" (p. 95).

As both a part of and *beside* traditional cultural norms, the magic circle inscribes a space that is culturally productive and built on the foundation of past production. Missing in most analysis of the magic circle is the interloper *within* the space: the gaming system itself. As products of the specific cultural and temporal locations in which they are produced, games carry with them their own ethics and values. As systems that dictate these values, games are “social technologies” (Flanagan, 2009, p. 9).

Like the technologies that mediate today’s “networked society” (Castells, 1996), the social technologies of gaming do not remain static. Their systems are updated and iterated upon such that they reflect changes in contemporary society’s relationship with these games. D&D, for example, has gone through a dozen systemic “editions” that have refined, altered, or clarified what play within the system entails.

In describing games as “social technologies,” Flanagan noted that

games, functioning as an ordering logic—a machine, or a technology—for creating social relations, work to distill or abstract the everyday actions of the players into easy-to-understand instruments where context is defamiliarized just enough to allow Huizinga’s magic circle of play to manifest. (p. 9)

The opportunities for transgressive social play (Salen & Zimmerman, 2004) are limited only by the imagination of players and the constraints of what a gaming system will allow; how a game is designed “carries implications for the social group” playing it (Flanagan, 2009, p. 9). However, although systems encourage iteration and systems change over time, the ideological assumptions underneath them largely do not.

Considering that games, as systems, are foundationally built on human beliefs and ideas, concerns about who authors these games and with what blind spots is particularly worrisome. Aligned with Vossoughi, Hooper, and Escude’s (2016) concern about cultural depictions of making, the need for “interrogating what is recognized as making” (p. 214), looking at the underpinnings of gaming systems is imperative. As cultural artifacts and social technologies, games are deeply embedded within the beliefs of the individuals who created them. Further, despite the limitations of who is characteristically playing and making games like D&D, the forms of learning within these systems can be robust.

Dungeons & Dragons as a system for cultural production

To contextualize this study’s emphasis on tabletop role playing and the broader gaming culture it falls within, I offer a brief history of D&D and acknowledge that lengthier histories of this game and its influence provide additional nuance (e.g., Peterson, 2012; Witwer, 2015). D&D, the first commercially released RPG, was first published in 1974 as three booklets authored by Dave Arneson and Gary Gygax. As described in the first *Players Handbook* (Gygax, 1978), D&D is “a fantasy game of role playing which relies upon the imagination of participants, for it is certainly make-believe, yet it is so interesting, so challenging, so mind-unleashing that it comes near reality” (p. 7). Although D&D spawned many other games within the genre it established, it did not remain static. Three years after its first release, D&D published two different, updated versions of its rules system. Gygax’s *Advanced Dungeons and Dragons* (1977, 1978, 1979) and the Eric Holmes–revised “basic” *Dungeons & Dragons* (Gygax & Arneson, 1977) gave players opportunities to *extend* the basic rules system and *clarify* the fundamentals of play for individuals new to the game. Following these releases, D&D’s publishers would release newer editions of the game at irregular intervals to correct and update the system, as well as to shore up a bevy of sales of the newly released books.

Regardless of which edition of the game is explored, the fundamentals of how to play D&D still revolve around the basic functions and beliefs of what adventure and storytelling look like. D&D, as a system for collaborative storytelling, is built around three primary modes of play and narrative development. As most clearly articulated in the 2014 release of the game’s fifth edition, D&D’s “three pillars of adventure” are “exploration,” “social interaction,” and “combat” (Wizards of the Coast, 2014a, p. 8). Like the assumptions D&D’s designers situated about race and gender within the gaming system, the forms of play and the ideologies it established shifted from one edition to another.

Although the virtual worlds of D&D have been significantly expanded with optional books, spin-off novels, and other gaming material, analysis in this article focuses on the “how to play” guides of the “basic” editions of D&D and *The Player’s Handbook* for various editions of the game across its 40-year history. These are the texts that nearly every player purchases and reads in order to play D&D; changes in ideology and representation are tracked in these foundational books.

While this article follows the development of D&D across 40 years, one significant addition is included in the figure above: Pathfinder (2009). With the release of the third edition of D&D, its publisher, Wizards of the Coast, encouraged third-party publishers and enthusiasts to legally publish and sell materials connected to the rules system of D&D. The Open Gaming License allowed for additions to and changes around the existing D&D ruleset. With a large contingent of D&D players disappointed by the changes to the rules found in the 2008 fourth edition of D&D, Paizo Publishing met this audience’s needs by forging a new path for loyal D&D players: They released Pathfinder as a revised version of the 3.5 edition’s ruleset. For the years after fourth edition’s release, Pathfinder was the most popular RPG being bought and played (ICv2., 2013). Although not technically a D&D product and published by a different company, the Pathfinder system is seen within the contemporary history of tabletop RPGs as an extension of the D&D ruleset and—even while D&D fifth edition is the top-selling RPG at the time that I write this—Pathfinder continues to support a large number of players of D&D.

In the 40 years since its release, the influence that D&D has had on popular, Western culture is profound. From influencing the designs of myriad video game titles and tropes (Harris, 2015; Kushner, 2004) to shaping the experiences of the aforementioned literary superstars, D&D has seeped into multiple facets of culture. Flowing along the same veins that course with inspiration from slaying dragons and liberating societies of mythical beings are the designed depictions of women, race, and power within the D&D system.

Methodology

Context for study

In considering the gap between studying learning within games and the roots of cultural stereotypes and symbolic violence happening *around* games, this article is part of a larger study focusing on learning and language practices within tabletop gaming communities. In 2014, I embarked on ethnographic research of player communities of tabletop role-playing communities in Northern Colorado. Over the course of 24 months, I participated in and socialized with myriad individuals engaged in public RPG communities. Following a lineage of ethnography within virtual world environments (Boellstorff, 2008; Chen, 2011; Dibbell, 1999; Nardi, 2010; Pearce & Artemesia, 2009), my fieldwork in this space focused on the interactions between players both in-game and “around the table,” as well as how broader Internet-driven networks of fandom shaped the localized experiences at my table. Recognizing that virtual worlds “are inherently performative spaces” (Pearce & Artemesia, 2009, p. 59), studying these games meant *playing* these games as well.

While conducting research within the virtual worlds created in D&D and other systems, it became clear that the foundations on which these games were established shaped the context of identities of players and their actions within the worlds. Noting that the systems of play guided the kinds of actions I observed in my data, this article’s analysis of the existing depictions of race, gender, and power within D&D uses Flanagan’s (2009) frame of games as “social technologies” as a primary conceptual framework.

Unarchiving humanity within the D&D system

For this study I read and annotated the primary rule books for D&D for each of the 12 editions listed in Table 1, as well as the wargaming text *Chainmail* (Gygax & Perren, 1971) that functioned as the

Table 1. Editions of Dungeons & Dragons.

Year Released	Edition Published
1974	Original <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>
1977	"Advanced" <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>
1977	"Basic" <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>
1981	Revised "basic" edition
1983	Re-revised "basic" edition
1989	"Advanced" second edition
1991	Re-revised "basic" edition
2000	Third edition
2003	3.5 edition
2008	Fourth edition
2009	Pathfinder
2014	Fifth edition

mechanical rules for the 1974 release of the game. The primary rule books for D&D—starting with the 1977 Advanced edition—are three books: the *Players Handbook* (PHB), the *Dungeon Masters Guide* (DMG), and the *Monster Manual* (MM). Taken together, these three books are the primary rules for how to play and have been subsequently released as a trio for every edition of D&D since 1977. The four "basic" editions of D&D simplified all of the rules into a single boxed product. These texts have gotten *longer* over time. Whereas the complete original version of D&D was a mere 110 folded, pamphlet-sized pages, the most recent PHB is 316 pages in length. For Pathfinder, a single (and hefty) 575-page *Core Rulebook* combines the PHB and DMG material. In total, I read and compared more than 5,500 pages of text across the versions of the game. This study's emphasis is on specific explanations of race, gender, and power and significantly limited the areas of cross analysis within the books.

After reading the texts, I looked at how issues of representation are addressed directly and indirectly, including gendered pronouns within the text and images of race and gender. As explained next, I specifically counted each individual represented within the pages of the book to quantify representation whenever possible.

A note before moving forward with the analysis in this article: Undeniably, both gender and race are complex. Particularly in the context of this study's emphasis on gaming culture's complicated and stifling relationship with feminist critique and lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer (LGBTQ) participants (Hurley, 2016), I recognize that gender is not a binary construction, and the analysis that follows does not argue as such. Likewise, although I do examine the images of individuals as depicted across editions of D&D, I do not believe that one's gender identity can be interpreted solely based on its depiction in pictures. However, considering the often egregious depictions of scantily clad women adorning the covers of fantasy and science fiction texts (that both inspire and have been inspired by D&D), the male gaze guides cultural distinctions of feminine performance within the virtual worlds of play. As such, the analysis that follows explores how these images reinforce what *being female* looks like within D&D. In the cases of images that are ambiguously gendered by artists and that do not have captions to clarify, I have given the books the benefit of the doubt and added these images as inclusive of representing females; as a result, the figures that follow may be slightly skewed to include *more* female representation than was intended within the pages of the books.

Findings

Gender construction and representation in D&D

Whether in basements, friends' living rooms, or the early gaming conventions organized by Gygax and friends, D&D was developed out of the wargaming communities comprised largely of White men, their complex rules systems, and their toys (Laws, 2007; Peterson, 2012; Witwer, 2015). By the time the first rulebook of D&D was released, the male-dominated genre—despite the game being playtested by Gygax's daughter (Witwer, 2015)—erased female players from within the purview of the book.

The first of the three books in the original D&D release was called *Men & Magic*. Likewise, the actual text refers to players using only male pronouns, beginning with the section labeled “Preparation for the Campaign”: “The referee bears the entire burden here, but if care and thought are used, the reward will more than repay him” (p. 3). Reinforcing the invisibility of female players within the rules of D&D, the three types of characters that players could choose were “Fighting-Men,” “Magic-Users,” and “Clerics.” Further, though there are distinctions between humans and other fantasy races like dwarves and elves, the rules distinctly note the options for “men” in terms of class features and the alignment they can choose (i.e., the moral code the characters follow). As the instantiation of rules they developed among male friends, Arneson and Gygax’s original rules reflect an absence of women.

By the time the first “*Advanced*” D&D rules were released 4 years later, women were acknowledged, but in limited and troubling ways. In the foreword to the first *Players Handbook* (Gygax, 1978), Mike Carr wrote that “D&D players, happily, come in all shapes and sizes, and even a fair number of women are counted among those who regularly play the game—making Dungeons & Dragons somewhat special in this regard” (p. 2). With the third sentence of the book, Carr attempts to draw women into the gaming genre, though the “even” exceptionalizes and exoticizes female players around the largely male-dominated space.

Further, the 1978 edition of D&D carries on the tradition of utilizing male pronouns but explains this decision:

Although the masculine form of appellation is typically used when listing the level titles of the various types of characters, these names can easily be changed to the feminine if desired. This is fantasy—what’s in a name? In all but a few cases sex makes no difference to ability! (p. 7)

One of the places where the choice of a character’s sex does make a difference is in physical ability. As demonstrated in a table (p. 9) depicting the maximum strength for characters, females have lower strength than males. In a system where you can be an elf, cast powerful spells, and barter with dragons, the notion that women could be as strong—if not stronger—than men was too preposterous to be developed within the system. This shift is striking because Gygax had to *intentionally* develop a system that diminished the power of women within the game. This was a system that was developed within the revision of the game with several years to develop this iteration of the system.

Although the strength restrictions were removed in later editions, the ever-expanding complexity of the game meant that players were given a chart to consider the height and weight of the characters they played. As the text helpfully explains, “Females tend to be lighter and shorter than males. Thus, the base numbers for height and weight are divided into male/female values” (p. 33).

Fifteen years after the game’s inception, an important change in the second edition (Cook, 1989) only exacerbated how pronouns were acknowledged. Addressing the use of the male pronoun, Cook wrote,

The male pronoun (he, him, his) is used exclusively throughout the AD&D game rules. We hope this won’t be construed by anyone to be an attempt to exclude females from the game or imply their exclusion. Centuries of use have neutered the male pronoun. In written material it is clear, concise, and familiar. *Nothing else is* [emphasis added]. (p. 9)

Explanations about pronouns would cease with later editions of D&D, starting with the third (Wizards of the Coast, 2000).

When Pathfinder was published in 2009, the *Core Rulebook*—and the books that followed its publication—focused on 11 “iconic” characters. Every time a fighter is shown in Pathfinder’s products it is always the same fighter: Valeros. This decision made depicting characters easy to recognize and created engaging transmedia narratives for Pathfinder players to follow from one text to another. More important, of the 11 initial core iconic characters in Pathfinder, six are female and are described with female pronouns. Notably, additional official Pathfinder books highlight that several of their iconic characters identify as part of the LGBTQ community including the shaman, Shadra—Pathfinder’s first transgender iconic character.

Picturing women in D&D

The shifts in the D&D rules over four decades highlight efforts from the game's designers to better acknowledge and bring in female players; this is despite the roots of "toxic pathologies" traced in the representation of the female body in D&D (Trammell, 2014).

Table 2 shows the number of images within the D&D core rulebooks that represent human and humanlike (i.e., elves, dwarves, etc.) characters. Within these images, I counted the total number of characters represented and the number of women within these. For example, if a photo illustrates a brawl with six figures and one of these individuals appears female, it is counted as a picture that includes women but also adds only one female to the total number of individuals represented in the book; a picture can both increase the percentage of figures featuring women and decrease the percentage of total women represented in the book. The numbers in this table, then, highlight both the percentage of pictures that include women and the total number of women within the book compared to men.

A few important considerations regarding this chart: The 1974 edition of D&D *appears* to have substantially higher number of women than some of the editions that immediately followed it; only the 1981 and 1983 editions have higher percentages until the 2000 release of the third edition. However, this is because there were so few pictures within the book in the first place. Further, of the four figures including women in this book, three of these characters are "witches," one is "medusa," and one is a topless "exotic amazon." Just because women are *represented* within this edition does not mean that they are represented *powerfully*.

Similarly, in the first and second editions of the game (those editions that specifically utilized the male pronoun throughout), although there were some women in the book, these images were frequently of women in scantily clad, sexualized attire or women in diminutive and powerless positions. For example, a somewhat typical image from the game's second edition shows a boy and girl cowering from a terror in the sky.

In looking at the percentages in Table 2, it appears that women are more prominently featured in the "basic" editions of D&D. With substantially simplified rules and limited options, these basic editions were useful beginning sources for players new to the mechanics of RPG. In seeing a representation gap between the *basic* and *advanced* versions of D&D, the publishers implicitly invite the question, which is discussed next, which games and which versions of these games are for whom?

Table 2. Total number of women included across historical editions of Dungeons & Dragons.

Year Released	Edition Published	Images With People	No. of Images That Include Women	% of Images With Women	Total No. of People Shown	Total No. of Women	% of Women
1974	Original <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>	18	4	22.22%	27	6	22.22%
1977	"Advanced" <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>	30	4	13.33%	80	4	5.00%
1977	"Basic" <i>Dungeons & Dragons</i>	9	1	11.11%	18	2	11.11%
1981	Revised "basic" edition	11	6	54.55%	27	8	29.63%
1983	Re-revised "basic" edition	26	10	38.46%	40	10	25.00%
1989	"Advanced" second edition	45	8	17.78%	77	8	10.39%
1991	Re-revised "basic" edition	23	8	34.78%	37	8	21.62%
2000	Third edition	48	17	35.42%	75	23	30.67%
2003	3.5 edition	45	16	35.56%	70	23	32.86%
2008	Fourth edition	61	34	55.74%	101	38	37.62%
2009	Pathfinder	82	51	62.20%	151	66	43.71%
2014	Fifth edition	77	42	54.55%	148	56	37.84%

Perhaps following in the path forged by Pathfinder, the fifth edition significantly increases the number of images of women, and qualitatively the women within the book are not as sexualized or placed in positions of terror as in previous editions. As these findings shift from looking at constructions of gender in D&D toward considering what race means within the rules, it is necessary to pause and consider that nearly all of the heroic characters—regardless of gender—are depicted as thin and able-bodied within the *Players Handbooks* of the various editions. Although these texts have moved to including a closer balance of participants, they have also done so while largely casting images around traditional, Western notions of beauty. In large part, as noted next, this primarily includes privileging whiteness as well.

Race and being “partially human” in D&D

Race, racism, and the cultural lessons that D&D teaches about innate feelings of distrust for individuals different from oneself are complicated. Fundamentally, race in D&D does not mean what it typically means in educational research. Instead, the races of D&D are largely a binary of “human” or “demi-human”—the humanlike characters that players can don within the game. Since its first release, players could become elves, dwarves, and halflings (Arneson & Gygas, 1974, pp. 7–8). Over the editions of the game, these options expanded to include other fantasy races such as gnomes and half-orcs. Although the rulebooks state that humans are the most common race found within the default world of D&D, there are many racial choices that players can make. Diversity breeds choice within the D&D system.

In the “basic” editions of D&D, race was simplified. Players would choose to be either a human, with class options (like magic-user, fighter, etc.), or a nonhuman character like an elf or dwarf:

Most D&D characters are humans. A human can be a Cleric, Fighter, Magic-User, or Thief. Humans are the most widespread of all intelligent beings.

A character may also be a non-human: a Dwarf, Elf, or Halfling. Each of these classes is also a separate race of beings. They are all commonly known as “Demi-humans,” because they seem to be partially human. (Gygas & Arneson, 1983, p. 23)

These basic editions of the game suggest a genetic determinism of what individuals can be and their capacity to excel at various aspects of D&D gameplay. Extending this work to the “advanced” versions of the game, in creating a character within D&D, one of the first choices a player makes is the character’s race. The decision affects mechanics and, in the earlier editions of the game, limits who and what an individual can become. Certain races are limited in how far they can advance within the game. In the second edition, for example, when looking at the cleric class, gnomes are restricted to reaching only the ninth level, halflings eighth, and elves 15th; humans are unlimited in their potential. Perhaps a utopian perspective of human exceptionalism, these limitations fundamentally highlight implicit assumptions about racial inferiority within the game.

Adding to these perspectives of some races being better than others, all of the rulebooks have highlighted how different races interact and view one another. In this first *Players Handbook*, Gygas (1978) noted that

there are also certain likes and dislikes which must be considered in selecting a racial type for your character. The dealings which a character has with various races will be affected by racial preferences to some extent. Similarly, the acquisition of hirelings by racial type might prove difficult for some characters if they go outside a narrow field. Your Dungeon Master will certainly take racial preferences into account during interaction between your character and the various races which he or she will encounter. (p. 18)

Racism is *built* into the D&D system. Early adventures published for D&D such as *A1: Slave Pits of the Undercity* (Cook, 1980) focus on players freeing slaves and fighting oppressive forces; although these adventures are set in a fictitious realm, racial differences drive evil intent and spark a tautology of who is inherently good or evil.

Across the editions of the game, race has meant a series of mechanical augmentations to a character and preset attitudinal beliefs about other races within the world. These are *fixed* assumptions about distinct races built into the ideology of the gaming system. Even in the most recent version of the game (Wizards of the Coast, 2014a), textual descriptions of races hint at bigotry and oppression within the game's history for different races. Half-orcs, for example, are described as having powerful "savage attacks" (p. 41) that provide opportunities for extra damage in certain situations. However, in *playing* such a character, participants also acknowledge that half-orcs have been largely despised by others:

Grudging Acceptance: Each half-orc finds a way to gain acceptance from those who hate orcs. Some are reserved, trying not to draw attention to themselves. A few demonstrate piety and good-heartedness as publicly as they can (whether or not such demonstrations are genuine). And some simply try to be so thought that others just avoid them. (Wizards of the Coast, 2014a, p. 41)

Histories of war, slavery, and rape and pillage are implied within this text about "grudging acceptance." Although such text does not dictate if a character is good or evil, it implies the values and beliefs that the world within this system imposes on individuals and what individuals impose on one another.

But what about "race" as we know it in today's "real" world? Even acknowledging that there are not cultural and ethnic differences among humans—let alone other fantasy races within the game—does not show up until the later editions of the game. Prior to the fifth edition (Wizards of the Coast, 2014a), most humans and demi-human images are White heroic characters. Building off the campaign setting of the Forgotten Realms, the fifth edition *Players Handbook* explains, "The material culture and physical characteristics of humans can change wildly from region to region" (p. 30). It continues,

In the Forgotten Realms, nine human ethnic groups are widely recognized, though over a dozen others are found in more localized areas of Faerun. These groups and the typical names of their members, can be used as inspiration no matter which world your human is in. (p. 30)

Detailing these different cultural groups, the book describes common physical traits such as different hair, eye, and skin tones alongside culture differences and beliefs. Similarly, though this study's focus emphasizes articulations of race and gender within the core rulebooks for the various editions of D&D, this study must also acknowledge the plethora of additional books and print-based materials that expand the cultural and racial options for D&D players. As early as the 1975 *Blackmoor* supplement (Arneson, 1975) to the 1974 edition of D&D, players have built off of cultural tropes of action films by introducing the "monk" class: martial artists largely inspired by kung fu films of the era (Peterson, 2012). This class was expanded by the 1985 book *Oriental Adventures* (Gygax, 1985). As the foreword to this volume makes clear, *Oriental Adventures* was developed from a White "occidental" gaze: "This new book is aimed at providing players and Dungeon Masters with the material they need to develop the 'other half' of their fantasy world" (p. 3). Trammell (2016) noted that the success of *Oriental Adventures* could be inferred as based on the desires of a "racist and sexist culture of American, Canadian, and British gamers." Similarly, the opportunity to play the *other* "other half" was provided with the 1992 release of *Al-Qadim*, a Middle Eastern expansion for the game inspired by Western versions of *One Thousand and One Nights* (Grub, 1992). The game's ongoing depiction and enchantment with exoticized, non-Western cultures shaped the foundations of D&D. Race is usually a physical concept that extends beyond simply endowing cultural identities of human beings. However, it also usually reinforces Western notions of Whiteness and ongoing fears of xenophobia. As both physical and cultural concepts within D&D, race and gender depictions are not defined solely by the game's author. Instead, players extend and build from the tools of narrative construction they are provided in order to collaboratively extend problematic representations embedded within this system.

Dungeon masters and the dynamics of play and power

Gender and race are constructed through the narratives that players choose to tell within the game. Choosing to be, within the virtual world of the D&D system, a male or female character, a dwarf or a human—these are choices that hinge on players’ decisions. They do, as just demonstrated, result in mechanical effects designed into the D&D rules system. However, unlike these player-facing choices, constructions of player power and agency are beyond the choices individuals make at the table. The actual rules of D&D dictate specific “repertoires of cultural practice” (Gutiérrez & Rogoff, 2003).

As D&D—and many RPGs that followed it—is a collaborative storytelling game, the individual who facilitates and guides the stories being told is called the Dungeon Master (DM). Elsewhere, I have written about how teachers can adopt the flexible practices of a DM in order to enrich their classroom learning environments (Garcia, 2016). However, in the original descriptions of DMs, this was a role that was much more prescriptive and punitive in its relationship with players than what is described in the contemporary editions of D&D.

The original editions of D&D refer to the DM as a “referee” and can be inferred as a rules interpreter. As Peterson (2012) noted, the role of the referee was seen as an “arbiter” of rules and permissibility within the wargaming circles from which D&D was created (p. 59). Unlike the collaborative nature of how D&D is described and understood today, the game was originally one in which DMs created and governed a virtual world and players were tasked as “organizers and adventurers to order and explore it” (Gygax, 1978, p. 7).

Players are guided to “cooperate with the Dungeon Master and respect his decisions. . . . Be prepared to accept his decision as final and remember that not everything in the game will always go your way!” (Gygax, 1978, p. 2). Further, earlier editions included additional rules of how players must conduct themselves with the DM. For example, some editions of the game (Gygax, 1977; TSR, 1991) called for mappers and callers:

The mapper is the player who draws a map of the dungeon as it is explored. One or more of the characters should be making maps, but one of the players must make the actual map.

The caller is a player selected by the other players to describe part actions so the DM doesn’t have to listen to several voices at once. (Gygax, 1977 p. 5)

Whereas all of the editions of D&D corroborate the fact that the DM “is the creative force behind a D&D game” (Wizards of the Coast, 2014b, p. 4), the earlier versions of the game mechanically reinforced subservience to this individual. Likewise, the DM often kept information hidden from her or his players. The books of monsters like the *Fiend Folio* (Turnbull, 1981) include the various creatures dwelling in the dungeons that players would encounter. To shield the content of books and notes from players, as well as to occlude the die rolls they made, DMs often place a physical barrier or screen between themselves and the players at their table. Likewise, the *Dungeon Master’s Guide* (Gygax, 1979) reinforces this aura of secrecy suggesting that DMs “must view any non-DM player possessing it as something less than worthy of honorable death” (p. 8).

Again, like the conceptions of gender, the severity of description of this role has diminished across the various editions of D&D. DM screens are still commonly used in gaming communities and current *Dungeon Master’s Guide* (Wizards of the Coast, 2014b), and other DM-related material (Laws, 2002; Vecchione, 2012) reinforce how DMs manage players. Issues of player control and enthusiasm are common within these texts.

Discussion: Studying within and around cultural systems

Although the findings in this study can be read as damning of a potentially sexist and racist history of a system that has shaped large swaths of contemporary geek culture, it is also a promising reminder that like people, cultural constructions, and systems *change*. In looking at the description of role-playing gamers in Gary Alan Fine’s (1983) formative ethnography of these communities in

the late 1970s and '80s, his analysis rightly describes the fact that the vast majority of players at the time were male wargaming enthusiasts (pp. 62–63). However, Fine's assumptions about gender at the time, although fitting in line with depictions of gender in the 1974, 1977, and 1989 editions of D&D, are out of step with the contemporary instantiations of D&D (e.g., "Women as female characters have little importance. Male players comment that female characters should be treated as property and not as human beings"; Fine, 1983, p. 65). The systems of D&D Pathfinder and their players are starkly different today.

Further, the depictions of gender and race in the D&D system are not invented whole cloth by Gygax and Arneson. As detailed in numerous accounts (Applecline, 2014a, 2014b, 2014c, 2014d; Ewalt, 2013; Peterson, 2012; Witwer, 2015), D&D was influenced by the tropes of wargaming tabletop games, as well as by the pulp narratives of writers like Robert E. Howard and H.P. Lovecraft. Assumptions of race and gender, then, can be traced further back to the lineage of cultural production of a group of male writers publishing near the turn of the 20th century. Gygax listed the authors who inspired his game design in the appendix of the 1979 edition of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*; unsurprisingly, the 30 authors listed are all White and only three (Leigh Brackett, Andre Norton, and Margaret St. Clair) are women (p. 224).

Tracing the Matryoshka Doll-like nesting of cultural influence and production, it is important for researchers in systems-driven environments to consider how culture constructs identities. Although there is an abundance of insightful research into how games shape socialization and learning (in both digital and nondigital contexts), such analyses cannot be studied as if games are isolated from the cultures that influence them or in which they are embedded. This study's findings reveal two methodological stances to consider when looking at communities of gaming, schooling, and myriad other learning contexts:

- (1) The cultural production and influence *around* a community must be explored. How individuals understand what happens within a gaming community, for example, is shaped and influenced by cultural factors external to the ecosystem being analyzed. In short, games are a part of culture, and culture seeps into their enactment.
- (2) The cultural production and influence from *within* the systemic design of cultural artifacts must be explored. As illustrated in this study, the human biases and beliefs of individuals that construct systems are embedded within systems. These guide beliefs and influence specific "cultural-historical repertoires" (Gutiérrez & Rogoff, 2003; p. 21).

Although cultural-historical analyses often attend to the preceding first point, the human-built foundations *within* systems may more easily be overlooked. Particularly as educational research considers biases, oppression, and equity in varied communities of practice, the role that cultural artifacts play in the shaping of meaning and understanding must be unpacked.

In exploring tribalism in the online virtual world of *World of Warcraft*, Bergnall (2008) argued that "stereotypes and cultural identities follow players into the game" (p. 119). Although the culture around online gaming reinforces Bergnall's claim, it is also worth recognizing that stereotypes and prejudices don't just flow *into* games: They are pushed out through systems' designs. From a cultural-historical perspective, we must consider that identity is "created from narratives that are floating around" (Sfard & Prusak, 2005, p. 18).

Finally, in looking at how human biases shape systems, which in turn shape players' experiences, the *purposes* of these systems must be reiterated. As a tool for creative, collaborative, and—ideally—*fun* storytelling and play, D&D's system must both guide and provide liberating opportunities for innovation. Particularly considering that the noncanonical edition of D&D—Pathfinder (Paizo Publishing, 2009)—seems to play a significant role in shifting embedded representations of gender, this appears to be a significant moment to explore the possibilities of player communities extending and reshaping systems. Further research is needed on how player communities are redefining who

games like D&D are for and what representation and identity in such games now looks like. Acknowledging that game design means creating rules for others to play within and around, Pearce and Artemesia (2009) questioned,

How do you design for meaningful play when the play itself is unpredictable, essentially out of your control? The social fiction of virtual worlds can thus be viewed as a confluence of imagination: that of the designer and that of the players. (p. 31)

D&D is a system of possibilities. Although these possibilities have been constricted in initial iterations, the possibilities for revision, dialogue, and production have proven ripe in opening up and diversifying what gaming and role-play mean and for *whom*. A critical understanding of how the foundational aspects of the system have shaped current forms of play only further enriches these contexts.

Although our constantly changing cultural interactions with systems like D&D create opportunities for these systems to change and *improve* over time, the flurry of death threats and harassment from the gamergate movement that gaming critic Anita Sarkeesian received highlights the ongoing vigilance needed around these systems (Wingfield, 2014). Sarkeesian's experiences reflect an additional layer of "cultural mediation" that is problematically "occurring over time" (Cole, 1998, p. 292). In particular, this study should remind us that individuals' agency can function as a positive disruption to the stereotypes built into systems (Sfard & Prusak, 2005). Although the initial language and images of D&D mean it is unsurprising that popular media—from the Netflix hit *Stranger Things* to the television series *Freaks and Geeks*—largely depicts primarily White male characters reenacting nostalgic sessions rolling dice with friends in the 1970s and '80s, this is a landscape that can change. By focusing on what happens *within* and *around* systems of cultural interaction, the possibilities for redefining systems and their communities become clearer.

Like video games, the changes in language, design, and political orientation in D&D occur only with the occasional release of new editions of the gaming system. It is a process that is arrested in its development and perhaps has taken an inordinate amount of time to move beyond problematic representations of race and gender.

Acknowledgments

I gratefully acknowledge the generous support of the National Academy of Education and the Spencer Foundation; they provided resources and mentorship that were crucial for completing this article. I also thank Bonnie Nardi and the two anonymous reviewers who helped me revise this work.

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